

We granted certiorari, 454 U. S. 1140 (1982), and we reverse and remand.

II

For more than a century and a half, the United States generally granted foreign sovereigns complete immunity from suit in the courts of this country. In *The Schooner Exchange* v. *M'Faddon*, 7 Cranch 116 (1812), Chief Justice Marshall concluded that, while the jurisdiction of a nation within its own territory "is susceptible of no limitation not imposed by itself," *id.*, at 136, the United States had impliedly waived jurisdiction over certain activities of foreign sovereigns. Although the narrow holding of *The Schooner Exchange* was only that the courts of the United States lack jurisdiction over an armed ship of a foreign state found in our port, that opinion came to be regarded as extending virtually absolute immunity to foreign sovereigns. See, e. g., *Berizzi Brothers Co. v. S.S. Pesaro*, 271 U. S. 562 (1926); Von Mehren, *The Foreign Sovereign Immunities Act of 1976*, 17 Colum. J. Transnat'l L. 33, 39-40 (1978).

As *The Schooner Exchange* made clear, however, foreign sovereign immunity is a matter of grace and comity on the part of the United States, and not a restriction imposed by the Constitution. Accordingly, this Court consistently has deferred to the decisions of the political branches—in particular, those of the Executive Branch—on whether to take jurisdiction over actions against foreign sovereigns and their instrumentalities. See, e. g., *Ex parte Peru*, 318 U. S. 578, 586-590 (1943); *Mexico v. Hoffman*, 324 U. S. 30, 33-36 (1945).

Until 1952, the State Department ordinarily requested immunity in all actions against friendly foreign sovereigns.

in which "the constitutionality of any Act of Congress affecting the public interest is drawn in question, the court shall certify such fact to the Attorney General." The Court of Appeals denied the motion without explanation, see App. to Pet. for Cert. 55a.

But in the so-called Tate Letter,⁹ the State Department announced its adoption of the "restrictive" theory of foreign sovereign immunity. Under this theory, immunity is confined to suits involving the foreign sovereign's public acts, and does not extend to cases arising out of a foreign state's strictly commercial acts.

The restrictive theory was not initially enacted into law, however, and its application proved troublesome. As in the past, initial responsibility for deciding questions of sovereign immunity fell primarily upon the Executive acting through the State Department, and the courts abided by "suggestions of immunity" from the State Department. As a consequence, foreign nations often placed diplomatic pressure on the State Department in seeking immunity. On occasion, political considerations led to suggestions of immunity in cases where immunity would not have been available under the restrictive theory.¹⁰

An additional complication was posed by the fact that foreign nations did not always make requests to the State Department. In such cases, the responsibility fell to the courts to determine whether sovereign immunity existed, generally by reference to prior State Department decisions. See generally Lowenfeld, *Claims Against Foreign States—A Proposal for Reform of United States Law*, 44 N. Y. U. L. Rev.

⁹ Letter from Jack B. Tate, Acting Legal Adviser, Department of State, to Acting Attorney General Philip B. Perlman (May 19, 1952), reprinted in 26 Dept. of State Bull. 984-985 (1952), and in *Alfred Dunhill of London, Inc. v. Cuba*, 425 U. S. 682, 711 (1976) (Appendix 2 to opinion of WHITE, J.).

¹⁰ See Testimony of Monroe Leigh, Legal Adviser, Department of State, Hearings on H. R. 11315 before the Subcommittee on Administrative Law and Governmental Relations of the House Committee on the Judiciary, 94th Cong., 2d Sess., 34-35 (1976) (hereafter *Hearings on H. R. 11315*); Leigh, *Sovereign Immunity—The Case of the "Imias,"* 68 Am. J. Int'l L. 280 (1974); Note, *The Foreign Sovereign Immunities Act of 1976: Giving the Plaintiff His Day in Court*, 46 Ford. L. Rev. 543, 548-549 (1977).